Chapter 4

A Wedding Ahead of Her Times

IT WAS AT THE AMRITSAR TENNIS COURTS THAT KIRAN MET BRIJ BEDI, A textile engineer by profession. The fathers of both Kiran and Brij were members of the Service Club of the city. Brij and Kiran were fellow tennis players. While Kiran was a national-level player, Brij was a university-level player. He admired Kiran for the standard of her game, commitment and personal discipline. Their tennis association grew and gradually got converted into a permanent relationship. Kiran and Brij 'tied the proverbial knot' in one of the simplest ceremonies that Amritsar had ever witnessed. On 9 March 1972, a very close group comprising their parents and friends went to the famous Shiva temple at 2 a.m. There, Kiran and Brij garlanded each other and accepted each other as man and wife. The same morning Kiran went back to her own home to take her usual big glass of milk from the hands of her mother as she was used to and to drop her younger sister Anu at the Sacred Heart Convent. She did not want Anu ever to feel that because her sister was married and had changed her residence, she was going to shed her responsibility towards her younger sister. From her mother's home Kiran drove (on her scooter) as earlier, straight to the Khalsa College for Women, where she used to teach political science to graduate classes. Her students and staff were all taken aback when they came to know that their madam had been married the same morning. For they saw no visible change in her. Kiran looked the same. In her dress and her looks. She was the same simple one. No jewellery, no makeup, nothing different. Three days later, at the joint reception for all their (the Peshawarias' and the Bedis') friends and relatives, Kiran wore a sari for the first time in her life.

What does she have against the sari? 'Nothing', she would reply. 'It's a graceful garment and makes women look very feminine.' And would she not want to look feminine? 'Let's put it this way,' she would say. 'I haven't got used to it at all, and dress, in my view, is a personal choice and a reflection of an attitude.'

To meet her is to realize what gender equality is all about.

Here was a wedding in which neither a paisa nor a minute was wasted. Even the reception was a joint one, with both sides (the bride's and the groom's) pooling in to share the expenses. There was neither any exchange of money nor any give and take, for such 'barter' was not acceptable to either side. It was truly a wedding of two educated and equal human beings. Kiran had already qualified for the Civil Services and was awaiting selection, which she was confident of. She also knew that it was not long before she would make her own home, contrary to the traditional practice of the wife moving into her husband's house.

She had been married in March 1972, and, on 16 July the same year, she created history when she reported for training at the National Academy of Administration in Mussoorie (a hill station now in the state of Uttarakhand) as the first woman in India (who would go on) to join the Indian Police Service. After the three-month foundation course, she next went to Mount Abu (in Rajasthan) to undergo another nine months of basic police training. She was the only girl in a batch of over 80